SHINDE VS. UDDHAV: HOW THEY STACK UP

UDDHAV THACKERAY

PROS

- Shinde unable to induce a split in party organisation
- Strong grassroots connect in Mumbai, built around old Marathi manoos base, the Thackeray name and uniquely militant cadres
- Can grow beyond old Sena straitjacket with outreach to North Indians, Buddhist Dalits/ Bahujans. Has soft corner among Muslims, Christians who see in him a gentle, cosmopolitan leader willing to crack down on hate crimes
- Perception of being a victim of BJP's vendetta politics

CONS

- Inaccessible, surrounded by coterie and lacks strong second-rung leadership after the Shinde camp's desertion, due to reluctance to groom and trust leaders with mass base
- Withering away of fear factor under Uddhav's white-collar leadership; fence-sitters could now switch to Shinde side
- Inability to inspire personal or mass loyalty like father Bal Thackeray
- Inherent contradictions of an old Hindutva party in alliance with "secular" parties like Congress, NCP, especially in sensitive regions like Marathwada

EKNATH SHINDE

PROS

- The appeal of an accessible, affable, down-to-earth mass leader risen from the ranks, with a state-wide network, not restricted to his base Thane or Mumbai
- Besides the Shiv Sena name and symbol, has a bulk of the original Shiv Sena legislative party
- The BJP's support
- Mumbai's changing demography, with traditional working-class Maharashtrian areas being gentrified, may work in favour of a pro-Hindutva BJP-Sena alliance

CONS

- Seen more as a loose, fractious federation of MLAs yoked together by opportunism and coercion than as a political party per se; no organisational depth
- Lack of strategic acumen as administrator; overshadowed by deputy CM Devendra Fadnavis
- Growing tensions with BJP. Contradictions in alliance: Sena's working-class Marathi base and nativist politics vs. BJP's mercantile, Gujarati leadership that may prey on Shinde camp to retain Hindutva monopoly
- Perception that there can be no Sena without Thackerays

clutch of petitions on the legality of the change of guard in Maharashtra. They are asking how the EC could give a verdict when the issue is still sub judice.

The EC's decision also comes at a time when the Shinde-BJP government is locked in a prestige fight with the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) in bypolls to the Kasba Peth and Chinchwad assembly seats, where the Congress and NCP, respectively, are up against an incumbent BJP on behalf of the MVA. Both are in the Pune belt, where the Sena's traditional Mumbai footprint has a spillover, especially in Kasba Peth, which is within the city.

But that's tangential to the Uddhav camp's trauma upon losing its name and symbol—inseparable from the Sena's first family for decades. It was Uddhav's grandfather, the activist 'Prabodhankar' Keshav Sitaram Thackeray, who suggested the organisation's name. The 'dhanushyabaan' was allocated to the party in 1989, and has strong resonance among the Mumbai voter. In regions like Marathwada, where religious cleavages run deep, it is a barely-veiled dare to the voter—'*Khan havaa, ka baan havaa* (Do you want Muslims to win or the bow-and-arrow)?' Now, Shinde, who claims to represent the true legacy of Sena supremo Bal Thackeray, is walking away with both, leaving Uddhav and his son Aaditya to begin from scratch.

There is jubilation in the Shinde camp. "The EC's decision will have a positive impact on the outcome of the battle over the Shiv Sena legacy. Fence-sitters and those in doubt will now cross over to our side," says a former Lok Sabha MP, who is now with the Shinde camp. Another Lok Sabha MP, who is on the same side, agrees. "When it comes to actual election contests, the party symbol has a strong loyalty and recall value, especially in regions like Marathwada. People blindly vote for the bow and arrow regardless of who the candidate is, which may actually lead to some of Uddhavji's men coming over to us. These developments may also increase his reliance on the Congress and NCP, which in turn, may affect his faction's appeal in regions that have a history of communal tensions."

So, is all lost for Uddhav and his remaining loyalists? Perhaps not. While Shinde may have the support of the bulk of the legislative wing and now recognition as the official Shiv Sena, the party organisation has by and large stayed loyal to the Thackerays. This is especially true in its stronghold of Mumbai, where its politics was born.

Uddhav also retains most of the Sena's network of *shakhas* (branches) in Mumbai. Many of these *shakhas* and the party headquarters—Shiv Sena Bhavan at Dadar—are controlled by the Shri Shivai Seva Trust, which is headed by Thackeray family loyalist and former minister Subhash Desai. Party mouthpieces *Saamana*, *Dopahar Ka Saamana* and *Marmik* are managed by Prabodhan Prakashan. Shinde will not find it easy to wrest control of these tangible and intangible assets.

He also lacks organisational muscle beyond bastion Thane. There are also